Slop / University

The Rack Forgets Slower Than the Rider

Cataloguing Why a Campus Bike-Stall Tag Outlives Its Claim

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The problem

Despite a decade of digital reservation systems governing shared campus infrastructure, little is known about what happens after a rider stops riding. A stall tag, once claimed, carries no mechanism that asks whether it should be released. Who notices first?

Objectives

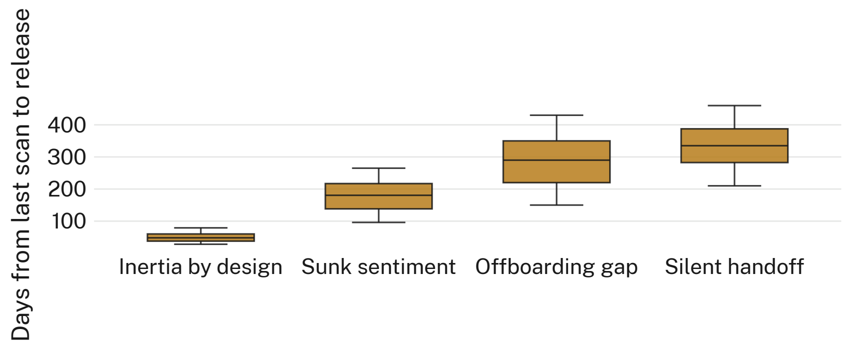
- Catalogue why a dormant bike-stall claim goes unreleased
- Compare how riders and Facilities staff account for the same persistence
- Locate points in the claim lifecycle where release could be prompted

Study design

- 34 semi-structured interviews (22 lapsed riders, no scan > 120 days; 12 Facilities & Security staff) · one semester
- Thematic coding to saturation (interview 27 of 34) · second coder cross-checked 20% of transcripts
- Typology applied to the full stall-tag register (161 dormant tags, 18-month window) to compute time to release

Findings

Four recurring accounts pattern the 34 interviews, rarely exclusive of one another. Register cross-tabulation (88 released tags) reproduces the same ordering: silent handoff persists longest, inertia by design clears fastest.



Among 88 stall tags formally released between January 2025 and June 2026, median dormancy ranged from 48 days under inertia by design to 335 days under silent handoff — a near sevenfold spread across the four accounts.

Discussion & conclusions

Persistence is a behavioural gap, not a technical one — the tag performs exactly as specified. Silent handoff resists fixes aimed at the original registrant, since the record never learns who kept riding. Next: a release prompt tied to ID-card deactivation, paired with a 60-day holding class.

References

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Ethics approval 2025/61; register data de-identified before cross-tabulation; no rider re-identified without consent.

“Nobody unclaims a stall. Eventually, someone just notices.”

Median dormancy before release ranged 48–335 days by account type (n = 88 tags).